



THE JUNKTOWN CRUSADE

A CRUSADE OF RUST



Knights Adrift in the Wasteland · A GM-Ready One-Shot

THE PITCH IN A BREATH

Seven hundred years ago, a company of crusader knights knelt in the dust of a burning battlefield and prayed for deliverance. Something answered. When the light faded they were standing in a street of corrugated scrap under a sun the color of a bruise, and a man with a two-headed cow was staring at them, and somewhere a machine was screaming in a voice only their holy relic could hear.

This is **Junktown** — a walled shantytown of salvage and desperation in the poisoned California of the year 2161, ruled by an honest sheriff who is one bad night from a gang war. The knights believe they have marched into Hell, or Purgatory, or the Holy Land laid waste by God's wrath. They are wrong about the theology and right about the danger. And the relic they have guarded for three generations is not a saint's finger-bone at all — it is the missing heart of the dying machine beneath the town, and the machine wants it back.

The Junktown Crusade is a genre-collision one-shot for three to five characters of roughly 3rd to 5th level, written for **D&D 5e (SRD 5.2)** and easy to run in any system. It is about faith meeting the atom, chivalry meeting the

wasteland, and a company of holy warriors deciding whether "home" is worth more than a town full of strangers who think they're insane. Expect culture-shock comedy, real dread, a mystery with a time-loop at its heart, and a finale where going home and saving Junktown may not be the same choice.

Tone: grim-but-warm post-apocalyptic fish-out-of-water, with wonder, gallows humor, and moral weight. Runtime ~4 hours (scales 2–6). Complexity medium. Rated PG-13: wasteland violence, radiation sickness, organ-harvesting implied, gang cruelty; grim, not gratuitous.

Other names it has answered to: *Deus Ex Wasteland, The Relic of Junktown, A Crusade of Rust.*

Unofficial fan content. *This scenario is a homebrew, non-commercial tabletop adventure set in the world of Fallout, which is the property of Bethesda Softworks / ZeniMax. It is offered as fan-made GM material and is not affiliated with or endorsed by the rights holders. All prose is original.*

WHAT THE TABLE SHOULD FEEL

Open on disorientation and dark comedy — armored knights in a scrapyard, quoting scripture at a brahmin, recoiling from a "hand-cannon," calling the ghoul a damned soul and the mutant a demon. Let the players laugh at the collision, because the laughter buys the later grief. Under the comedy, seed unease: the ground hums, the relic grows warm, and nobody in Junktown will say what's under the town.

By the middle, the knights should feel the wasteland's real logic close around them — that honor is a luxury here, that the "demons" are people, that the sheriff they'd instinctively serve is sitting on a secret that could kill everyone. Near the climax comes the vertigo of the reveal:

they were not delivered by God and they were not damned by the Devil; they were *summoned*, by a machine, to return a thing they have worshipped, and the way home is the same lever that could doom the town.

What the players should want, by the end, is to reconcile two vows that no longer fit together: the oath that says *go home and finish the crusade* and the newer, wordless one they've made to the frightened people of a rust-heap town. What they should argue about afterward is whether a knight's duty is to his own age or to whatever age he's standing in. Run it with affection for both worlds — medieval and atomic — and never let either become a punchline for long.

FOR THE PLAYERS (SPOILER-FREE)

*You are sworn brothers and sisters of the **Order of the Argent Sepulchre**, holy warriors who have guarded a sacred relic — the **Argent Heart** — across a long and bloody crusade. In the smoke of a lost battle you prayed to be delivered from your enemies. You were heard. Now you stand in a land that cannot exist: a sky the color of a wound, cattle with two heads, men who kill with thunder held in one hand, and a fortress town built from the bones of a world you have never seen. They speak your tongue, mangled. They think you are madmen or omens. And the relic at your side has begun, for the first time in living memory, to grow warm.*

Bring a knight, a squire, a warrior-cleric, or a pilgrim of the Order — anyone bound by an oath and a code (3rd–5th level, any martial or faith-leaning SRD build; you know sword and prayer, not gunpowder). Before we play, tell me two things: the vow your character has sworn, and the thing in the old world they are most afraid they will never see again.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (GM ONLY)

Beneath Junktown, buried and forgotten, lies **Site LAZARUS** — a pre-War government research bunker that housed an experimental temporal-displacement reactor. In the last days before the bombs, a team led by **Dr. Elias Vane** tried to use it to "evacuate" personnel *forward* through time, out of the war. The test tore loose a critical component — the reactor's resonance core, a fist-sized argent device — and flung it not forward but *backward*, centuries into the deep past, where it was found by medieval hands, mistaken for a holy relic, enshrined, and eventually entrusted to the Order of the Argent Sepulchre. The knights have carried it, and venerated it, ever since. It is the **Argent Heart**. It is the reactor's missing piece.

For two hundred years the reactor has run wounded and leaderless, kept from meltdown by a single survivor: Vane himself, ghoulished by the radiation, half-mad with age and guilt, still tending the machine in the dark. Junktown was built on the surface above him by scavengers who never knew what they stood on — and the town's precious water is drawn, though no living Junktowner understands this, from the reactor's still-functioning coolant reclamation. The tremors, the "ghost-lights" in the old cellar, the way the well tastes of copper before a quake — all of it is the reactor.

It is dying now. Its surges have grown strong enough to reach across time and *pull* — and when the knights carried

the Argent Heart within range during the largest surge in a century, the machine reeled them in like a fish on a line, dragging them forward to reclaim its own heart. That is why they arrived, and why they specifically. The reactor is calling its component home, and the next great surge — days, maybe hours away — will either open a stable door (a way back for the knights) if the Heart is restored, or tear an unstable rift that irradiates and swallows Junktown if it is not.

Nobody in town knows the whole of it. **Sheriff Killian Darkwater** inherited a locked cellar and a family rule — *never open the deep door* — and keeps it out of stubborn caution, not knowledge. **Gizmo**, the casino boss who wants Killian dead, has heard there is "old-world treasure" below and has quietly begun digging, which is accelerating the collapse. The **Skulz** gang are a lit match near the powder. And Vane, the Warden below, knows everything and wants only two things: to give the Heart back, and to finally be allowed to die. If the players do nothing, Gizmo's dig breaches the reactor during a surge and Junktown drowns in blue fire. What they can change is everything about how — and whether — the door opens, and who is standing in Junktown when it does. What cannot be solved cleanly is the last equation: the Heart can go home, or the Heart can hold the machine steady, but the knights cannot carry it through the door *and* leave it behind to save the town.

THE WORLD: JUNKTOWN AND THE WASTELAND

It is the year 2161, and the world ended long ago. Two centuries back the bombs fell, and the survivors of

southern California crawled out into a desert of rust, radiation, and ruin. There is no kingdom here, no church,

no law but the strong — only scattered settlements clinging to water and salvage, and between them a poisoned wild of raiders, mutated beasts, and the walking dead who did not have the decency to stay dead. Into this, the knights have fallen like a page torn from another book.

Junktown is one of the lucky places: a walled town of scrap-metal shacks and salvaged neon, a day's hard walk from the crater-town of the Hub. It survives on three things — water, salvage, and the uneasy truce between the man who keeps the peace and the man who breaks it.

HOW THE TOWN CAME TO BE, AND WHAT IT STANDS ON

The founders were scavengers who found, in a dead stretch of desert, a place where a hand-pump could still draw clean, cold water when everywhere else drew poison. They walled the miracle in and called it Junktown. They never asked *why* the water was clean; the desperate rarely do. The truth — that the water comes up through the reclamation lines of a buried pre-War reactor — is the town's foundation in the most literal sense, and no living soul remembers it. The oldest family, the **Darkwaters**, built their store over the only surface entrance to the deep places, sealed it, and passed down a single inherited superstition: *the deep door stays shut*. Sheriff Killian keeps that rule the way you keep a grandfather's watch — out of loyalty, not understanding.

RECENT HISTORY, AND THE TREMORS NOBODY EXPLAINS

Junktown has known a rough peace for years, held between Killian's law and Gizmo's greed. But lately the ground has begun to *shudder* — small quakes that crack the well-housing and rattle the bottles in the Skum Pitt. The last year brought stranger things: the well-water tasting of copper before each tremor; a blue glow seen twice in the boarded cellar of the Darkwater store; a caravan brahmin that would not stop lowing at the ground until it was led away. Killian blames old mine-works. Gizmo, hearing "old-world tech," saw profit and began paying the Skulz to dig, in secret, from an old drainage tunnel beneath his casino. The digging is why the tremors are worsening. And three nights ago, the largest tremor yet coincided, to the minute, with the arrival of a company of armored strangers who fell out of empty air in the market square — a coincidence only Vane, in the dark below, understands is not one.

THE LOOK, SOUND, AND STINK OF IT

Junktown is corrugated iron and salvaged chrome, lit at night by scavenged neon that buzzes and flickers — the

Skum Pitt's sign the brightest thing for miles. It smells of brahmin dung, gun-oil, cheap liquor, and the ozone tang that rises from the well before a quake. The soundscape is a low grind of generators, the bleat of two-headed cattle, the click of dice and the crack of distant gunfire, and — if you press your ear to the ground near the well, as the knights inevitably will — a deep, rhythmic hum, like a cathedral organ holding one endless note. Water is currency and life; a canteen is wealth; a working weapon is power; and everything, *everything*, is made from the corpse of the old world.

POWER, AND WHO HOLDS IT

Two men rule Junktown between them. **Killian Darkwater** is sheriff, mayor, and shopkeeper, an honest hard man who hangs murderers and means it when he says the town runs on order. **Gizmo** is the fat king of the Skum Pitt casino, who launders the town's vice and wants Killian dead so he can rule without a conscience in his way. Beneath them squirm the **Skulz**, a gang of bored, cruel youths who will work for whoever pays and break whatever's nearest. Killian's power rests on the townsfolk's fear of chaos; Gizmo's on their appetites and debts. Neither knows that the true power in Junktown is fifty feet down, humming, and running out of time.

THE CONTRADICTIONS WORTH PLAYING

Junktown is a knot of ironies a clever party can pull. It is a town of law whose lawman keeps a locked secret he does not understand. It is a haven of clean water that is slowly being poisoned by the very machine that cleans it. It is a place where the "monster" below — a radiation-scarred ghoul the town would shoot on sight — is the only reason the town still stands. And now it holds a company of holy knights who believe they are in Hell, protecting a relic that is the one thing that could save the "damned," if only they understood what it was. Every one of these can turn under the players' hands.

FOR THE KNIGHTS SPECIFICALLY

To the Order, everything here is scripture misread. The wasteland is the world after God's judgment; the radiation is a curse or a miasma; guns are "hand-cannons," sorcery or witch-work; ghouls are damned souls doing penance; super mutants (spoken of, distant) are demons; the two-headed brahmin are omens. Their instinct is to find a lord to serve, a wrong to right, a soul to save. Junktown offers all three — Killian as the lord, the gang war as the wrong, the frightened people as the souls — and the campaign turns on whether the knights can adapt their code to a world that has no place for it, or break trying.

THE SECRET ENGINE

Everyone in Junktown believes something comfortable and wrong. The townsfolk think the strangers are madmen or a bad omen and the tremors are old mine-works settling. Killian thinks the deep door is just family superstition. Gizmo thinks there is treasure below worth killing for. The knights think they have been delivered — or damned — by the hand of God. Not one of them is looking at the truth: that a dying pre-War time-reactor lies beneath the town, that it drew the knights across seven centuries to reclaim the resonance core they have worshipped as the Argent Heart, and that its next surge will either carry them home or bury Junktown, depending on whether the Heart is returned to it.

The truth is meant to land hard but fair, and it is foreshadowed from the first minute: the relic warming near

the well, the copper taste before the quakes, the blue light in the cellar, the organ-hum in the ground, the impossible timing of the knights' arrival, the way the "holy" Heart is patterned with fine geometric etchings no medieval hand could cut. Only **Dr. Elias Vane** — the ghoul Warden below — knows all of it, and he has been trying to be heard for days, through failing intercoms the townsfolk mistake for ghosts and through a knight, **Brother Corwin**, who arrived in an earlier, smaller surge weeks ago and has been raving prophecy in the streets ever since. The reveal reframes the opening completely: the knights were not saved and not condemned. They were *called*, like a key to a lock, and the miracle they thanked God for was a machine's dying reach.

THE PRESSURE THAT DRIVES IT ALL

Three wills pull against each other while the ground counts down. **Killian** wants order and the town intact, and he will keep the deep door shut and the peace kept even as both become impossible. **Gizmo** wants Killian dead and the "treasure" below, and his secret dig is the hand tightening on the reactor's throat. **Vane**, the Warden, wants the Heart returned and his two-century vigil ended, and he will trade the knights their road home for it. Around them, the reactor itself is the true antagonist — not a mind, but a clock, surging harder each hour. Ordinary Junktowners

are caught because the water that keeps them alive and the machine that will kill them are the same thing. The knights matter because they alone carry the missing piece, they alone can walk between the sheriff, the crime boss, and the horror below without a stake in the town's old feuds, and they alone must choose what the Heart is for. It all detonates when Gizmo's dig breaks through during a surge — or when the knights, understanding at last, decide whether to open the deep door themselves.

THE POWERS OF JUNKTOWN

KILLIAN'S LAW

Their mark is a tin star, and their creed is that a town without order is just a slower kind of grave. Sheriff **Killian Darkwater** is mayor, lawman, and shopkeeper in one, and he holds Junktown together by force of will and a shotgun he is genuinely reluctant to use. His faction is the town's spine — a handful of deputies, the militia of frightened shopkeepers who would rather have him than Gizmo, and the moral authority of a man who hangs murderers after a fair hearing and not before. What Killian wants is simple and sincere: the town intact, the peace kept, and the deep door shut. What he misunderstands is that all three have quietly become impossible, and that the family superstition he honors is the only thing standing between Junktown and the truth below. He will see the armored knights as either a threat to order or, if they prove themselves, the deputies he desperately needs; he can offer them lodging, legitimacy, weapons, and the run of the town; he can threaten them with the noose if they side with Gizmo or spill blood in his streets. Ignored, he tries to keep the lid on alone, and fails. In the finale he is the man who can rally the town to evacuate or to fight — but only if the players make him open the door he has sworn never to touch. The

rumor is that he'd rather burn Junktown than let Gizmo have it. The secret is that he has heard the hum through his cellar floor his whole life and has spent forty years pretending he hasn't.

GIZMO'S HOUSE

Loaded dice are their sign, and appetite is their gospel. **Gizmo** — vast, wheezing, and shrewd — rules the Skum Pitt casino and the town's every vice, and he wants one thing above all: Killian in the ground so he can own Junktown outright. His people are the casino's muscle and management: **Izo**, his mute enforcer; **Neal**, the weary bartender who sees everything; and a rotating debt of gamblers and hired guns. Gizmo commands money, information, and the willingness to do what Killian won't. Lately he has learned there is "old-world tech" beneath the town and has begun paying the Skulz to dig toward it in secret from a tunnel below the casino — which is exactly the hand throttling the reactor. He believes the tremors are just the cost of getting rich; he has no idea he is digging his own grave and the town's. He will try to hire the knights as exotic muscle to kill Killian, offering caps, guns, and comfort; he will threaten to expose or frame them if refused. Ignored, his dig breaks through and triggers the

breach. In the finale he can be the accelerant that dooms Junktown or, if turned or removed, the pressure that eases. The rumor is that he had the last sheriff-hopeful poisoned; the secret is that Gizmo is dying — a bad heart, months left — and the "treasure" is his desperate bid to be remembered as a king instead of a crook.

THE SKULZ

A spray-painted skull is their tag, and boredom sharpened into cruelty is their whole philosophy. The Skulz are a gang of young wastelanders — **Vinnie** their swaggering leader, and a dozen others with knives, pipes, and stolen pistols — who terrorize Junktown's edges and take coin from Gizmo for the digging they don't understand. They want respect, thrills, and to matter, and they misunderstand everything else, including the fact that the tunnel they are cutting is killing the town they live in. They can be hired, frightened, humiliated, or — surprisingly — *recruited*, because more than one Skul is a scared kid who would follow a genuine hero if one ever bothered to look at them, and armored knights preaching honor may be exactly that. They will menace the players early to establish the danger; ignored, they escalate the dig and start a fire that becomes the point of no return. In the finale they are chaos that can be turned to evacuation-muscle or left to loot and burn. The rumor is that they killed a shopkeeper's daughter; the truth is muddier and sadder, and a knight who learns it can crack the gang open.

SITE LAZARUS (THE MACHINE AND ITS WARDEN)

It has no banner, only a rad-symbol stenciled on rusted blast doors, and its will is the will of a dying man and a dying machine. Fifty feet beneath Junktown lies the pre-War temporal reactor and its last keeper, **Dr. Elias Vane**, ghoulished and ancient, who has held back meltdown for

two centuries out of guilt and cannot any longer. Vane's "faction" is the reactor's automated remnants — flickering intercoms, a limping maintenance robot or two, sealed doors that still answer old codes — and his one desperate agent above ground, poor mad **Brother Corwin**, a knight from an earlier surge whom Vane has been trying to use as a mouthpiece. What Vane wants is to return the Argent Heart to its cradle, stabilize the reactor long enough to open a clean door home for the knights, and then, at last, be permitted to die. He knows the entire truth and will give it freely to anyone who reaches him. He can offer the way home, the science behind the "miracle," and control of the machine; he can do nothing by force, for he can barely stand. Ignored, the reactor surges unchecked and the Site becomes the grave of Junktown. In the finale, his console is where every choice is finally made.

HOW THEY PULL ON ONE ANOTHER

Killian and Gizmo are the open war, law against appetite, each certain the other will destroy the town. The Skulz are Gizmo's cat's-paw and Killian's headache, loyal to coin and thrill rather than either man. Vane, below, is unknown to all of them and yet holds all their fates, because the dig that Gizmo pays the Skulz to cut is breaking the machine Vane cannot save alone. Everyone depends on the water; the water depends on the reactor; the reactor depends on the Heart the knights carry — so the whole town, feuds and all, hangs from a relic none of them can even recognize. The levers a sharp party can pull are personal: Killian's inherited dread of the deep door, Gizmo's terror of dying unremembered, Vinnie's hunger to be led, Vane's longing to rest. Topple Killian and the town fractures into looting before the surge even comes; topple Gizmo and the dig stops and the clock slows; reach Vane and the truth changes every calculation at once.

A WALK THROUGH JUNKTOWN

Seven places hold the night, and an eighth waits below for the end. Each leads with words to read aloud, then what it offers those who push at it.

THE GATE AND THE MARKET SQUARE

The wall is a patchwork of car doors and sheet steel, and the gate is a hanging slab of it worked by a bored man with a rifle. Beyond, a rutted street runs between shacks of corrugated iron, strung with buzzing neon and the smell of dung and gun-oil. A two-headed cow chews garbage in the road. And here, in the square, is a scorch-ring in the dirt where three nights ago the air tore open and armored strangers fell out of nothing.

This is where the knights arrived and where the town first takes their measure. The gate-guard, **Kalnor**, is jumpy and

rifle-shy of the "tin-men," and the square is where rumor, commerce, and the first Skulz shakedown all happen. Here the players learn the shape of the town — Killian's law, Gizmo's casino, the tremors, the missing water — and here, if they think to examine the scorch-ring, they find the dirt fused to glass in a perfect circle and the Argent Heart warming at the nearness of something below. The square connects to everything: the store, the casino, the well, the inn. As the clock advances, the tremors crack the square's hardpan and the scorch-ring begins, faintly, to glow again.

DARKWATER'S STORE AND THE SEALED CELLAR

Shelves of scavenged wonders — canned food older than kingdoms, coils of wire, a wall of guns behind the counter — and behind it all a hard-eyed man cleaning a shotgun who watches you the way a shepherd watches wolves. A trapdoor in the back room is barred with iron and painted, in a child's long-faded hand, with the words KEEP SHUT.

Killian's store is the town's heart and the players' likeliest first ally or first obstacle. Here they can trade (though their coin is worthless and their armor is treasure), take Killian's measure, and — crucially — feel the hum strongest through the cellar floor and see the blue light seep around the barred trapdoor when a tremor hits. The sealed cellar is the only surface entrance to Site LAZARUS, and Killian guards it out of inherited dread; winning his trust, or his desperation, is one road down. The store connects to the square and, through the cellar, to the deep places. As the clock fills, the trapdoor's glow brightens and its iron bar grows warm, and Killian's certainty begins to crack.

THE SKUM PITT

Neon and noise and the reek of spilled liquor; dice clatter, a jukebox wheezes a pre-War tune, and on a reinforced dais sits a mountain of a man whose small eyes miss nothing. Down a back stair, past a locked door the bouncer won't discuss, the floor trembles and somewhere below a pick is striking stone.

Gizmo's casino is the town's vice and the campaign's hidden fuse. Here the knights can be tempted, hired, cheated, and threatened; here Gizmo makes his pitch to have Killian killed; and here, below the gambling floor, runs the **secret dig** — a drainage tunnel the Skulz are cutting toward the "treasure," which is the second, illicit road down to the reactor and the direct cause of the worsening quakes. Players who investigate the back stair, follow the noise, or lean on Neal the bartender can find the dig. The Pitt connects to the square and, through the dig, to Site LAZARUS. As the clock advances, the dig breaks through more of the old structure, and each surge sends gamblers screaming into the street.

DOC MORBID'S

A lean-to clinic that smells of chemicals and something sweeter underneath. The doctor is quick, competent, and never quite meets your eye, and there is a locked cold-room in the back that hums with power no scrap-town clinic should have.

Doc Morbid is the only healer in Junktown and the only one who can treat the radiation sickness the knights will soon suffer — but he is a body-parts profiteer, and his cold-room runs on a scavenged power-tap that (a clever party will notice) draws its current from the same buried source as the well. He is a morally compromised helper: he'll trade treatment for coin, salvage, or a favor best not examined too closely. Here the players learn what radiation does, get a lead on the buried power source, and face an early moral snag when they discover where some of the Doc's "supplies" come from. The clinic connects to the square and, via the power-tap lead, to the truth below.

THE CRASH HOUSE

A flophouse of stacked bunks and snoring drifters, run by a tired woman with a lockbox. In the corner, a filthy man in the rotted remains of a surcoat rocks and mutters — and the surcoat bears the cross of your Order.

The town's inn is the rumor-mill and the site of a gut-punch: **Brother Corwin**, a knight of the Argent Sepulchre who was pulled through in a smaller surge weeks ago and has been raving in the streets since, is sheltered here. He is the bystander who knows too much — he has seen the light below, been half in Vane's failing intercom-signal, and speaks the truth in the shape of prophecy ("the iron saint sleeps under the well; he begs the Heart come home"). Decode his ravings and the players have the shape of the mystery. The Crash House connects to the square and threads every other location through its gossip.

THE WELL AND THE PUMP-HOUSE

The town's treasure: a hand-pump and a stone housing over a shaft that gives cold, clean water where all the world gives poison. The metal of the pump is worn smooth by three generations of grateful hands. When you stand near it, the relic at your side grows warm as a living thing, and the water, just now, tastes faintly of copper.

The well is the reactor's face on the surface, and the single most important clue-site in town. The relic reacts here unmistakably; the copper-taste precedes every tremor; and a character who studies the pump-housing finds pre-War stamped steel and a maintenance hatch, rusted shut, marked with a rad-symbol — a third, hard road down. The well connects the square, the store, and (through the hatch) the Site. As the clock fills, the water clouds, then glows, then fails — and a town without water is a town in panic.

THE SKULZ' HOLE AND THE DIG

A cellar den of stolen liquor, spray-paint, and swagger, where hard young faces size you up and finger their blades. Behind a curtain of hanging chains, a raw tunnel bores down into the dark, and the kids working it cough and joke and have no idea what they're cutting into.

The gang's hideout doubles as the dig-head. Here the players can confront, frighten, or win over the Skulz, and here they see the dig up close — the pre-War concrete breached, the rad-warnings the kids can't read, the blue seep in the tunnel's throat. It is the fastest and most dangerous road down, and the place where the point-of-no-return breach is most likely to happen. The Hole connects to the Skum Pitt (Gizmo's coin) and, through the tunnel, to Site LAZARUS.

SITE LAZARUS

Blast doors and dead fluorescent tubes; a corridor of pre-War steel furred with rust and rot; and at its end, in the sick blue glow of a reactor that should not still be burning, a figure that was once a man turns its ruined face toward you and says, in the cracked remains of a scholar's voice: "You came. You brought it back. Thank God — or thank me, it hardly matters now."

The buried Site is the finale, a place to inhabit rather than a room to clear. Here waits **Dr. Elias Vane**, the ghoul Warden, the failing reactor, and the cradle where the Argent Heart belongs. Here the whole truth is told and the last choice is made: return the Heart and open the door home, hold the machine steady at a terrible cost, or let it all come down. You reach it three ways — Killian's sealed cellar (with his trust or his desperation), Gizmo's secret dig (through the Skulz), or the well's rusted hatch (with tools and nerve) — so the door the party comes through is, once again, the faction whose hand they took. Play Vane as a person: brilliant, broken, unbearably tired, and desperate to do one right thing before the end.

THE ROADS BETWEEN

Everything opens off the market square. The honest road down is Killian's cellar, won by trust. The crooked road is Gizmo's dig, taken through the Skulz. The hard road is the well-hatch, cut open with the Doc's tools and a strong back. And the road that opens only after the players understand — after Corwin's ravings are decoded or Vane's signal is heard — is the knowledge of *why* they are here at all, which turns a scavenger-hunt into a homecoming.

THE PEOPLE YOU'LL MEET

Each is built to come alive in a sentence — lead with the face and the voice, and reach for the rest as the players dig.

SHERIFF KILLIAN DARKWATER

Lean, grey, and unhurried, Killian cleans his shotgun the way a monk tells beads, and he means every word when he says Junktown runs on order or it doesn't run at all. He wants the town whole and the peace kept, and he keeps the barred trapdoor in his back room shut because his father did and his father's father did — a loyalty he mistakes for wisdom. *"I've hanged three men in this town,"* he tells the knights, *"and I slept fine after every one, because the law's the law. Give me a reason to trust you and you'll eat tonight. Give me a body in my street and you'll hang like anyone."* He has heard the hum under his floor his whole life and pretended not to, and that lie is the crack the players can widen. Threaten his order and he moves against you; earn his trust and he deputizes you and, at the end, can be persuaded to open the door he swore never to touch; ignore him and he tries to hold the lid alone and is buried under it.

GIZMO

A wheezing mountain on a reinforced throne, Gizmo misses nothing and forgives less, and he wants Sheriff Killian dead so badly he can taste it. *"You're a curiosity, tin-man, and curiosities make me money,"* he says, dabbing his brow. *"Kill me a sheriff and I'll drown you in caps and clean water. Cross me and I'll bury you in this town so deep even God loses the address."* What no one knows is that Gizmo is dying — a failing heart, a season left — and the "old-world treasure" his dig is chasing is a last, desperate grab at being remembered as a king. His men fear him; his body is betraying him; and his dig is strangling the town. Threaten him and he sics Izo and the Skulz on you; take his deal and you're complicit in the breach; expose his dig and you can turn the town against him; and if a knight ever offers him the one thing he actually craves — to be remembered as something better than a crook — even Gizmo can be moved.

DR. ELIAS VANE, THE WARDEN

Two hundred years of radiation have left him barely a man — lipless, lidless, voice like a rusted hinge — but the mind behind the ruin is sharp, sorrowful, and courteous to a fault. He tended the reactor alone in the dark since the day the bombs fell, holding back its death out of guilt for the test that broke it, and he is so tired. *"I sent the core into the past to save it,"* he rasps. *"I did not know the past would make a god of it, or that saving it would take me two hundred years to undo. Give it back, knights. Let me put my house in order. Let me rest."* He knows the whole truth and gives it without price; he can open the road home or hold the machine steady, and he will explain that these are not the same thing. He can force nothing — he can barely stand — and he wants only the Heart returned and permission, at last, to die. He is the campaign's grief and its grace.

BROTHER CORWIN

Once a proud knight of the Order, Corwin was pulled through weeks before the party in a smaller surge, and the wasteland and Vane's ghostly signal have hollowed him into a street-prophet in a rotted surcoat. He rocks, he mutters, he weeps — and everything he says is true, wrapped in scripture. *"The iron saint sleeps beneath the well,"* he chants. *"He is not damned, brothers — he is drowning, and he begs the Heart come home. The angel that took us was made of wheels and fire. We were not saved. We were summoned."* He is the bystander who knows too much and cannot make anyone listen; decode him and the players hold the shape of the mystery early. Show him kindness and he steadies enough to guide them; ignore him and he wanders into the wasteland to die with the truth still locked in his ruined head.

DOC MORBID

Quick-handed, evasive, and never quite meeting your eye, Doc Morbid is the only medicine in Junktown and a ghoulish profiteer who sells what the dead no longer need. He is the morally compromised helper: he alone can treat the radiation the knights will soon suffer, and his price is coin, salvage, or a question left unasked about the cold-room out back. *"I fix what the wasteland breaks,"* he says, washing his hands. *"Where the parts come from is between me and God, and God stopped visiting Junktown a long time ago."* His illicit power-tap draws from the same buried source as the well — a clue for the sharp — and his help is real even when his ethics are not. Turn on him too early and the knights lose their only cure; use him and they owe a debt that will sit uneasy on a knightly conscience.

VINNIE AND THE SKULZ

Vinnie leads the Skulz with a stolen pistol and a swagger that's mostly fear, and what he wants, under the cruelty, is to matter to someone. *"We run these streets, tin-man,"* he sneers — and his eyes flick, just once, to the sword on your back the way a hungry kid looks at bread. The Skulz dig for Gizmo's coin and don't understand they're killing the town; they menace the players early to set the stakes. Frighten them and they scatter and escalate; humiliate them and they nurse a grudge that becomes the fire; but see them — offer a scared kid a code and a captain worth following — and a knight can peel the gang open and turn its chaos into evacuation-muscle at the end. There is a real wound under Vinnie's bravado, and the party that finds it changes the whole southern flank of the finale.

NEAL THE BARTENDER

Wry, watchful, and bone-tired, Neal pours Gizmo's liquor and keeps Gizmo's secrets only as long as the tips are good. He is the warm, funny lifeline in a hard town, and he knows where every body is buried — including the sound of picks under the floor. *"You want my advice, sir knight? Drink up, keep your voice down, and don't ask what's under the back stair,"* he says, already telling you exactly where to look. Tip him, charm him, or simply treat him like a person, and Neal becomes the players' best source of town truth and the fastest way to find the dig.

KALNOR THE GATE-GUARD

Jumpy, young, and rifle-shy of the "tin-men," Kalnor is the players' first face of Junktown and its first test — a nervous kid with a gun who could wave them in or start a bloodbath depending on how they carry themselves. He is minor, but he is the tone-setter: handle Kalnor well and word spreads that the knights are reasonable; handle him badly and the whole town meets them braced for a fight.

TRISHA OF THE WELL

A sharp-eyed girl of ten who fetches water for half the town, Trisha has noticed everything the adults explain away — the copper taste, the blue light, the way the ground "sings" — and she'll tell it plainly to anyone who treats her like she matters. She is the victim with agency and the child whose safety, when the surge comes, gives the finale its human stakes. She is never harmed on screen; her danger is the town's danger, and protecting her is the emotional thread that turns a puzzle into a rescue.

THE TRAIL OF THE TRUTH

The mystery cannot dead-end. Every load-bearing fact can be reached three ways by at least two different kinds of clue, and three people — **Brother Corwin** (decode his

prophecy), **Neal** (town gossip), and **Vane** himself (who tells all, freely, to anyone who reaches him) — exist to hand a stuck party whatever it has missed.

That **the knights came from a machine, not a miracle** is the first wall, and it cracks three ways: the scorch-ring in the square is fused to glass in a geometric circle no lightning makes; the Argent Heart, cool for generations, now grows warm whenever the party nears the well or the cellar; and Brother Corwin says it outright, if madly — *"we were summoned, not saved."* The comfortable misreading is divine deliverance; what confirms it is Vane, or the moment a player holds the Heart to the well and feels it pull.

That **there is a structure beneath Junktown** is told by the organ-hum through the cellar floor, by the pre-War stamped steel and rusted rad-hatch in the well-housing, and by the breached concrete at the bottom of the Skulz' dig. Townsfolk call it old mine-works; the rad-symbols say otherwise.

That **the town's water comes from that structure** the sharp will assemble from the copper taste that precedes every quake, from Doc Morbid's cold-room drawing current off the same buried tap, and from the way the well clouds and fails in lockstep as the reactor worsens. *Good luck and clean ground*, the town believes; the failing water proves the lie.

That **the "holy relic" is the machine's missing heart** is the hinge of it all: the Argent Heart is etched with fine

geometric patterns no medieval smith could cut, it warms and hums in answer to the depths, and both Corwin and Vane name it plainly — *the core must come home*. Pilgrims' faith says it is a saint's relic; the cradle in the reactor, shaped to receive it exactly, ends the argument.

That **Gizmo's dig is causing the collapse** the players can learn by noticing the tremors worsen by the day, by following the sound of picks below the Skum Pitt's back stair, by Neal's tired warnings, or by finding the dig-head in the Skulz' Hole. That **Killian's cellar hides the door** is written on the KEEP SHUT trapdoor, in the blue light that seeps around it during tremors, and in the family rule Killian will eventually confess. That **a Warden lives below and knows everything** is betrayed by the "ghost voices" on failing intercoms, by Corwin's half-channeled prophecy, and by the maintenance-robot a diver might glimpse in the dark — all of it resolved the moment they reach Vane. And that **the next great surge is nearly here** is impossible to miss: the tremors climb, the Heart grows hot enough to blister a bare hand, the water glows, and Vane, if reached, gives the countdown in plain words — hours, not days, and the last truth with it, that the Heart can carry them home or hold the machine steady, but never both.

HOW THE NIGHT RUNS

This is a one-shot on a clock, and the clock is the reactor. The minimum path is clean: the knights arrive and orient, follow the warmth of the relic and the town's rumors toward the buried truth, reach Vane by one of three roads, learn that the Heart can send them home or save the town but not both, and choose at the reactor's cradle before the final surge. Everything else — the feud, the gang, the Doc, the prophet — is texture and leverage over that spine.

Across four hours it tends to breathe like this. The first quarter-hour is arrival and shock: the fall into the square, the gate, the first taste of the wasteland's rules. The next half-hour is orientation and the first choice, as Killian takes their measure, Gizmo makes his offer, and the Skulz test them. From there, an hour of investigation — the well, the prophet, the Doc, the dig — as the truth assembles and the tremors worsen. Near the midpoint comes the reversal: the players understand there is something *alive and dying* beneath the town, and that Gizmo's dig is killing

it and them. Then the point of no return — a breach, a surge, or the players' own decision to open the deep door — and the descent. The finale at Site LAZARUS runs perhaps forty-five minutes; the last fifteen belong to the door, the departure, and what they leave behind.

Each act has its escape hatches. In **"Fallen Among Devils"** the goal is simply to survive first contact and orient; if the players flounder, the relic's warmth and Corwin's ravings point the way, and Neal will explain the town for the price of a drink. In **"The Thing Beneath"** the goal is to assemble the truth; a stuck party gets it from Corwin decoded, from Neal, or from Vane direct. In **"The Deep Door"** the goal is to reach the cradle and choose; whichever road they take — cellar, dig, or hatch — all three end at Vane. The point of no return is the breach or the open door, after which quiet investigation ends: the reactor surges, the water fails, the town panics, and the only question left is what the Heart is for.

THE OPENING

The last thing you remember is the smoke of a lost battle and a prayer torn from your throat. Then light — white, total, wrong — and a lurch as if the world dropped out from under your feet. Now you are standing in cold red dust under a sky the color of a three-day bruise, in a street of shacks built from strange smooth metal, and the smell is dung and hot oil and something that stings the back of the throat. A beast with two heads chews garbage six feet away and regards you without interest. A gaunt man on a gate-platform has leveled a black iron rod at you with shaking hands. And at your hip, cool and silent since your grandfather's grandfather carried it, the Argent Heart has begun, very faintly, to grow warm.

The gate-guard **Kalnor** finds his voice first, high and scared: *"D-don't move! What in the hell are you? Where'd you — you just fell out of the air, I saw it, everybody saw it!"* A knot of townsfolk has gathered at the edge of the square, half afraid, half gawking; among them a filthy man in a rotted surcoat bearing the cross of the Order suddenly lifts his head and wails — *"They're here! The Heart is here!"*

Oh God, they brought it home!" — before he's dragged back by an innkeeper. The visible problem is that the knights are surrounded, unarmed of any local footing, and one nervous kid away from a bloodbath. The hidden clue is the scorch-ring under their feet, fused to smooth glass in a perfect circle. The reason to act now is written in the wailing prophet and the warming relic. And the first choice is simply *how do armored strangers who think they're in Hell handle a frightened boy with a gun?*

Three first moves, and each opens the town. If they **stand down and parley**, Kalnor calls for the sheriff, and Killian's arrival becomes the players' introduction to Junktown's law. If they **go to the raving knight**, Corwin gives them their first thread — mad, but true — and marks them as kin to the town's resident lunatic, which is its own complication. If they **draw steel or bolt**, the square erupts, the Skulz smell weakness and move in, and the players learn the wasteland's first lesson the hard way. However it breaks, within five minutes the knights are moving, and the relic at their side is warmer than it was.

SCENES WORTH RUNNING

Seven set-pieces carry the night, plus the descent. Run them in whatever order the players' choices dictate; each moves information, a relationship, a resource, or the clock.

The Sheriff's Measure is the town's law taking stock of its strangest problem. Killian summons or receives the knights, reads them like a hand of cards, and offers a simple bargain — behave, and be fed and tolerated; make trouble, and hang. It's a social scene about first trust, and it plants the KEEP SHUT trapdoor in the players' minds. Handle it well and Killian becomes an ally who can later be moved to open the door; badly, and the law is a wall between them and the cellar road.

Gizmo's Invitation is the tempter's scene. Summoned to the Skum Pitt, the knights are wined, flattered, and asked — obliquely, then plainly — to murder a sheriff. It's a moral pressure-test that reveals the feud, the casino, and (for the observant) the sound of picks beneath the back stair. Refuse and Gizmo turns cold and dangerous; play along and they're complicit in what's coming; dig into the noise below and they find the campaign's fuse.

Blood in the Street is the Skulz putting the strangers in their place — a shakedown that can become a brawl, a standoff, or, remarkably, a recruitment. Run it as danger with a door in it: these are cruel, frightened kids, and a knight who fights them off *and then offers Vinnie something to believe in* changes the gang from a threat into a resource. Mechanically, treat the Skulz as **Bandits** with a leader as a **Thug**; the fight is short and the town is watching.

The Prophet's Riddle is Brother Corwin in the Crash House, the mystery handed over in the shape of scripture. It's a roleplay-and-decode scene: kindness steadies him,

cruelty or neglect loses him to the wasteland. Every true beat of the plot is in his ravings if the players listen — the iron saint, the well, the summoning, the Heart that must come home.

The Well That Sings is the wonder-and-dread nexus. At the pump the relic blazes warm, the water tastes of copper, and if the players are there when a tremor hits, the ground *sings* and blue light bleeds from the rusted hatch. It's the scene where the supernatural framing curdles into something stranger and more physical, and where three roads down first become visible.

The Doc's Price is the wasteland's moral grime up close. When radiation sickness first bites — and it will, near the dig or the hatch (treat as levels of exhaustion, or poison with a Constitution save) — Doc Morbid is the only cure, and his cold-room is the only lead on the buried power. It's a scene about owing something unclean to survive, and about a knightly conscience meeting a doctor who long ago made his peace with the unforgivable.

The Dig is the hazard scene and the likeliest breach. Below the Skum Pitt or in the Skulz' Hole, the players find the tunnel biting into pre-War concrete, the rad-warnings the kids can't read, and the blue seep in its throat. It is the fastest road down and the most dangerous; lingering as a surge hits risks the point-of-no-return breach, cave-ins (Dexterity saves), and a face-full of the reactor's sickness.

The Descent to Site LAZARUS is the finale, and it has its own section below.

Every scene should either warm the relic, worsen the tremors, turn a faction, or hand over a piece of the truth — usually more than one at once.

THE OTHER LAYERS OF PLAY

Three quieter systems give the night its body. The first is **discovery**: a curious party learns the truth by wandering (the scorch-ring, the well's stamped steel), by asking (Neal's gossip, Corwin's riddles, an old scavenger who remembers the founders "walling in a miracle"), by studying (the Heart's inhuman etchings, the Doc's power-tap), by following the water and the picks, and by noticing what's absent — no one can say *why* the well is clean, and everyone changes the subject when asked. The wasteland leaks the truth everywhere; the players need only be the first people in two centuries to actually look.

The second is the **social weather**, and for knights it is treacherous. Their armor is a fortune that makes them targets; their oaths make them predictable; their scripture makes them sound insane. The town reads them by how they treat the weak — protect Trisha or a bullied gambler and doors open; swing steel in the street and every hand turns against them. Killian respects competence and honesty; Gizmo respects usefulness and fears nothing but death; the Skulz respect strength and secretly crave belonging; Doc respects coin. Threats work on the weak and backfire on the proud; a knight's word, once given, is worth more here than caps, precisely because no one in Junktown expects anyone to keep one.

The third is **danger**, which is constant and mostly not a duel. The true threat is the reactor's clock and the surge

that ends it; around it move the Skulz (**Bandits**), Gizmo's muscle and Izo (**Thugs** and a **Veteran**), wasteland raiders at the walls (**Scouts** and **Berserkers**), radscorpions in the dark (**Giant Scorpions**), and — below, if things go very wrong — feral ghouls stirred by the surges (**Ghouls** and **Zombies**, straight from the Bestiary). Firearms are the great equalizer and the knights' great terror: treat a pistol as a ranged martial weapon dealing 2d6, a "thunder-stick" the Order will call witchcraft until they've seen enough of it. Radiation is the invisible enemy — exhaustion that the Doc alone can cure. Violence here is always costly: kill a Skul and you make orphans of the rest; kill in Killian's street and you hang. The knights' instinct to solve problems with the sword is, itself, one of the campaign's dangers.

And the whole thing rides on the **mystery's spine**: the core question is *what took us, and can it send us home?* Every false answer the knights carry — that this is Hell, that the ghouls are demons, that the relic is holy — still teaches something true on the way to the real one. If they accuse the wrong culprit (Gizmo, say, of witchcraft) the error still leads them toward the dig; if they solve it early, the night becomes the harder question of *what will you do with the answer?*; and if they never piece it together, Vane will tell them plainly at the cradle, and the choice lands all the same.

THE CHOICES WITH NO RIGHT ANSWER

Five hard decisions run through the night, each built so no option is clean. There is **the sheriff and the crime lord** — whether to serve Killian's order (and be bound by its noose), take Gizmo's coin (and become the murder weapon in a feud), or refuse both and stand alone in a town that respects only power. There is **the gang** — whether to break the Skulz by force (and scatter cruelty across the wasteland) or redeem them by example (at the risk of trusting knives). There is **the Doc's bargain** — whether a knight may accept healing bought with the parts of the dead, and what honor costs when the alternative is dying of the invisible curse. There is **the Warden** — whether the

ghoul below is a damned thing to be put down, as every instinct of the Order screams, or a suffering man owed mercy and thanks. And there is **the Heart itself**, the choice the whole night bends toward: to carry the relic home through the door and leave Junktown to the surge, to seat it in the cradle and save the town but strand the Order in the wasteland forever, or to find some third, costly road — destroy the machine, or take Vane's place tending it — that spares the town without a clean way home. Voice the strongest case for every side through someone the knights have come to respect, and let the table carry the weight. There is no answer here that does not cost a vow.

THE RISING CLOCK — THE REACTOR'S COUNTDOWN

The night tightens in seven surges as Site LAZARUS dies. Advance it roughly every half-hour, or whenever the players force a major scene; narrate each stage through the relic's heat, the water, and the ground. Gizmo's dig and any breach *accelerate* it; stopping the dig, easing pressure on the Site, or seating the Heart *slows* it; and reaching Vane lets the players understand and, briefly, steady it. Let it fill and the reactor tears open beneath Junktown in blue fire.

It begins with **the warming** — the relic grows warm and the tremors are still small enough to explain away. Then **the copper well**, as the water sours before each quake and Trisha and the brahmin grow restless. Then **the blue light**, seeping from the cellar trapdoor and the well-hatch during tremors, impossible now to ignore. Then **the dig bites deep**, as Gizmo's tunnel breaches pre-War concrete and the quakes climb hard, cracking walls across town. Then

the first venting, when a surge pushes radiation up through the dig and the well and the sickness starts to spread — the Doc's door is mobbed. Then **the water fails**, the well clouding to glowing sludge and the town tipping from unease into panic and flight. And finally **the tearing**,

the great surge: if the Heart is not in its cradle, the reactor rift opens and takes the lower town; if it is, the door home stands ready and the machine holds — for exactly as long as the Heart remains.

TOOLS FOR THE LIVING WORLD

Roll or pick to keep Junktown breathing between scenes.

RANDOM EVENTS (D12)

D12	EVENT — WHAT HAPPENS / THE CLUE IT CARRIES
1	A tremor drops bottles off a shelf; a Skul laughs too loudly to hide his fear. The dig is close.
2	The relic warms sharply as the party crosses the square. Something below just moved.
3	A gambler flees the Pitt swearing he heard "a ghost in the walls." Vane's intercom.
4	Trisha tugs a knight's sleeve: "The water tasted like pennies again. It does that before it shakes."
5	Two of Gizmo's thugs shadow the party, waiting for an order. The feud tightens.
6	A caravan arrives, refuses to stay the night — "this town's got a bad hum to it."
7	Brother Corwin is being stoned by children; intervene, and he gives up a true clue.
8	A radscorpion, driven up by the tremors, boils out of a crack in a back alley.
9	Blue light pulses under the Darkwater trapdoor; Killian pretends not to see it.
10	A Skul collapses coughing, skin blistered — the dig's sickness, though no one names it.
11	Doc Morbid quietly offers to buy a "spare" from anyone who dies tonight. He's not joking.
12	The ground sings for a full ten seconds and every dog in Junktown howls. A surge climbs a stage.

RUMORS (D10)

D10	RUMOR (T TRUE · F FALSE · H HALF-TRUE · ! DANGEROUS)
1	"Killian's got old-world treasure locked in his cellar." (H — a door, not treasure)
2	"The tin-men fell out of the sky. Omen of the end." (H)
3	"Gizmo's digging for something under the Pitt." (T!)

D10 RUMOR (T TRUE · F FALSE · H HALF-TRUE · ! DANGEROUS)

4	"The well's haunted. My gran heard it singing." (H — the reactor)
5	"Doc Morbid buries fewer folk than die. Do the math." (T!)
6	"That mad knight in the Crash House prophesied the shakes before they started." (T)
7	"The Skulz killed a girl at the south wall." (H — it's muddier, and Vinnie knows)
8	"Gizmo's dying. That's why he's gone reckless." (T)
9	"There's a devil under the town, and the water's its spit." (H — a ghoul, and its coolant)
10	"Go down the deep door and you don't come back." (F — but it feels true)

COMPLICATIONS (D10)

D10 COMPLICATION — ESCALATES WITHOUT BLOCKING

1	A tremor collapses a passage; find another road down.
2	A knight's armor is "requisitioned" by a debt Gizmo suddenly calls in.
3	Radiation sickness bites a party member (a level of exhaustion) mid-scene.
4	Corwin wanders off toward the wasteland with a clue still in his head.
5	Killian demands the knights disarm before entering his store.
6	The Skulz set a fire as a distraction — it spreads.
7	Trisha follows the party somewhere dangerous.
8	A firearm misfires or a knight refuses to touch "witch-thunder" at the worst moment.
9	Izo corners a lone party member with a message from Gizmo.
10	A surge climbs a stage early; the lights die and the ground sings.

WHAT THE KNIGHTS CARRY AWAY

Rewards here are survival, salvage, allegiance, and terrible knowledge. There is the material wasteland kind — caps

that mean nothing to a knight and everything to the town, a working sidearm the Order will distrust, clean water

worth its weight in blood, a suit of pre-War armor from the Site, stimpaks and rad-away from Doc Morbid's shelves. There is the social kind: Killian's deputyship, Neal's loyalty, a redeemed Vinnie and a gang turned honest guard, Trisha's fierce devotion. There is forbidden knowledge — the truth of the bombs, the war, the centuries, and the machine that made a god of their relic. And there are the costly, story-shaping prizes: **the Argent Heart** itself, now

understood, which can open the door home or hold back the end but not both; **Vane's testament**, a data-slate that explains everything and could, in the wrong hands, be used to build such a machine again; and **the door home** — a reward that is also the campaign's central wound, because to take it is to choose one world over another. For each, name what it costs and who else wants it; in Junktown nothing is free, least of all salvation.

THE FINALE — SITE LAZARUS

The end is a place to inhabit, not a fight to win. However the players come down — through Killian's cellar with his blessing or his breakdown, through Gizmo's dig with the Skulz at their backs, or through the well-hatch with the Doc's crowbar — the three roads meet in a corridor of dead fluorescents and rusted steel, and end in the sick blue glow of the reactor chamber, where **Dr. Elias Vane** turns his ruined face to them and says, *"You came. You brought it home. Now let me tell you what you've been carrying, and what it will cost to put it down."*

The surge is climbing as they arrive. The reactor's cradle stands open, shaped to receive the Argent Heart exactly; Vane, barely able to stand, lays out the whole truth and the whole cruelty of it. Above them, the town's fate hangs on the next few minutes: Gizmo's dig may be collapsing, the Skulz may be fleeing or looting, Killian may be trying to evacuate a panicking town, and the water is already failing. The wonder of the scene is the machine itself, and the knowledge that these seven strangers crossed seven centuries to stand here; the dread is the rising blue light and the ground's rising scream; the sacrifice is that every road out costs something that cannot be bought back.

They can seat the Heart and **hold the machine steady**, saving Junktown — but the door home closes with the cradle filled, and the Order is stranded in the wasteland for the rest of their lives, to make what peace they can with a

world of rust. They can take the Heart and **open the door home**, stepping back into their own century — but the cradle stays empty, the surge tears the reactor open, and Junktown burns behind them as they leave, a choice they will carry to their graves. They can seek the **third, costly road** — destroy the reactor outright (no home for anyone, but a clean, final end to the danger, and perhaps a slower death for a waterless town), or have one of their own or a willing soul (Vane cannot; he is too far gone) **take the Warden's place** at the machine, holding it by hand so the others may go home. And they can **fail** — arrive too late, or fall to arguing while the surge crests — and let the tearing take the lower town. Vane will beg only one thing regardless: that they let *him* die, at last, once his two-century vigil is someone else's to bear or no longer needed.

Prior choices decide what's possible. A town evacuated (Killian rallied, the Skulz turned, Trisha safe) means the tearing, if it comes, costs far fewer lives. A Gizmo stopped or turned means the dig isn't actively collapsing the chamber as they work. A Vinnie redeemed means muscle to hold the corridor against the feral ghouls a surge stirs up. And a Vane treated with mercy rather than a blade means an ally who spends his last strength helping them thread the impossible needle. No path is combat-gated; the knights can win this with a decision as surely as with a sword.

HOW IT CAN END

Home, and ashes behind them. The knights take the Heart through the door and stand again under a medieval sun — and know, forever, that Junktown died so they could. Within a week the Order is whole but haunted; within a year, some cannot sleep, and one has ridden back to a battlefield to die cleanly. The wasteland remembers them as the tin-men who came from the sky, took the town's treasure, and left it to burn.

Stranded, and a town saved. They seat the Heart, the tremors still, the water runs clean — and the door is gone. Junktown wakes to find its strange saviors are now its strangest citizens, knights with no century to return to. Within a year they are Junktown's iron backbone: Killian's deputies, Vinnie's teachers, the wall's last line. It is exile, and it is a home.

The hand on the machine. One of them stays below, taking Vane's place at the reactor so the rest can go home or the town can live — a living sacrifice, remembered in Junktown as the new saint beneath the well, and mourned in the old world as a brother who never came back. Vane, freed, dies with something like peace.

A clean, cold end. They destroy the machine. No one goes home; the danger is over; and Junktown must learn to live without its miracle water or die slowly trying. A bittersweet, honest ending for a table that refuses the easy miracle.

The tearing. They fail, or choose too late, and the reactor rips open. The lower town is lost in blue fire; what the knights saved or doomed above decides how many walk out of the wasteland afterward — and whether the Order's

crusade ends here, in a grave that isn't even in the right millennium.

For each, play it forward — the morning, the week, the year — and tell the players what Junktown says of the tin-men who fell from the sky, what vow each knight broke or

kept, and what smoulders on for a sequel: the data-slate in the wrong hands, the door that might be opened again, the town that still hums.

NOTES FOR THE GM

Lean into the collision and it runs itself. Play the knights' world with total sincerity — their faith is real, their code is real, their horror at guns and ghouls is real — and play Junktown with equal sincerity, so neither becomes a joke. Let the comedy of the mismatch breathe early; it earns the grief later. Describe the reactor's approach through three dials you can turn any time: the relic's heat, the water, and the ground. Feed stuck players the truth through Corwin, Neal, or Vane. Keep firearms scary and radiation scarier. And when in doubt, ask a knight what their oath demands, then show them why the wasteland makes it impossible — that tension is the adventure.

To shorten to two hours, open in the square mid-crisis with a tremor already shaking the town, cut to the well and the dig, and go down. To expand to six, run the full feud as its own act, add a wasteland trek to a second Site entrance,

and give each knight a personal wasteland temptation. As a three-session arc, make the first session the feud and the fish-out-of-water, the second the mystery and the descent, the third the fallout of whichever ending — a stranded Order building a life, or a crusade returned to a home that no longer fits. Dial up the horror with the feral ghouls and the sickness; dial up the heart with Trisha and a redeemed Vinnie; dial up the tragedy by making the home-versus-town choice truly mutually exclusive and personal.

A note on tone and safety: this is grim territory — radiation death, organ-harvesting, cruelty to the vulnerable, the despair of exile. Keep the gore off the page, set lines and veils before play, and remember the wasteland's cruelty should make the knights' stubborn decency shine, not smother it. Trisha and other children are never harmed on screen.

A PAGE FOR THE PLAYERS

Junktown, year 2161. A walled town of scrap and neon in a poisoned desert, ruled between an honest sheriff, **Killian Darkwater**, and a crime boss, **Gizmo**, who wants him dead. The town survives on one miracle: a well that gives clean water where all the world gives poison. Lately the ground shakes, the water sours, and strangers in armor fell out of the empty air three nights ago. Everyone knows the tin-men are either mad, cursed, or an omen — and everyone's too busy surviving to care which.

You are those strangers: sworn of the **Order of the Argent Sepulchre**, guardians of the holy relic called the Argent Heart, delivered — you believe — by God from a lost battle into this hell. You know the sword and the prayer, not the gun and the machine. Build a knight, squire, warrior-cleric, or pilgrim (3rd–5th level, martial or faith-leaning). Come ready to say: the vow you have sworn, and the one thing from the old world you fear you'll never see again.

THREADS TO TIE A KNIGHT IN

Six hooks, each cut to fit. **The Captain** commands the company and feels the weight of every life in it — home is a

duty owed to those they left, and every wasteland kindness is a temptation to abandon it. **The Doubter** lost their faith

on the crusade and finds, horribly, that the "miracle" here is a machine — which either damns everything they believed or finally frees them. **The True Believer** is certain this is a holy trial and reads every clue as scripture, and must decide what faith means when the relic turns out to be a reactor's heart. **The Squire** is young, out of their depth, and dazzled by the wasteland's freedom from feudal chains — the world that might make them something other

than a servant. **The Healer** (a warrior-cleric or field-chirurgeon) is undone and fascinated by Doc Morbid's medicine and the invisible curse of radiation, and tempted by knowledge that isn't holy. And **the Penitent** carries a sin from the old world and sees in the wasteland a chance to die well or be redeemed — and in Vane, a mirror they'd rather not look into. Each arrives with a vow, a fear, and a reason the choice at the reactor will cut them personally.

THE WORLD CONTINUITY MAP

Proof that nothing here is orphaned — every piece connects to a cause and to play.

ELEMENT	SPRINGS FROM (CAUSE)	CONNECTS TO	HOLDS / POINTS TO	SHAPES WHICH ENDING	ELEMENT	SPRINGS FROM (CAUSE)	CONNECTS TO	HOLDS / POINTS TO	SHAPES WHICH ENDING
Site LAZARUS reactor	Pre-War time-displacement experiment (the war)	The well, the cellar, the dig, Vane, the knights' arrival	The whole truth; the cradle; the surge clock	All endings pivot here	Dr. Vane (the Warden)	Scientist who ran the fatal test; ghoulish survivor	The reactor; Corwin (mouthpiece); the water; the knights	The full truth; the finale choices	The Sacrifice; his own release
The Argent Heart (relic)	Reactor core hurled into the past by the first test	The knights (carried it), the reactor (missing piece), Corwin, Vane	The way home / the stabilizer — the core dilemma	Home vs. Stranded vs. Sacrifice	Brother Corwin	Pulled through an earlier, smaller surge	The knights (Order); Vane (channels him); the Crash House	The decoded mystery (clue-refill)	Guides players toward any ending
The knights (PCs)	Summoned across time to return the Heart	Every faction (as outsiders); the relic; Corwin (kin); Vane	The Heart; the final choice	All	Doc Morbid	Wasteland scarcity; a doctor who compromised	The power-tap (same source as well); radiation cure	Clue: buried power; the moral snag	Whether the party survives to choose
Killian Darkwater	Darkwater family built the store over the sealed door	The cellar road down; Gizmo (feud); the town	Cellar entrance; evacuation muscle	Town saved / evacuated	The well / clean water	Reactor coolant reclamation	The whole town's survival; the reactor; Trisha	Clues: copper taste, stamped steel, hatch	Panic / evacuation timing
Gizmo	Dying, wants to be remembered; heard of "treasure"	The Skulz (pays the dig); Killian (feud); the reactor (accelerant)	The dig road down; the breach trigger	The Tearing (if unchecked)	Trisha	A child who noticed what adults deny	The well; the town's human stakes	Plain-spoken clues; the rescue thread	Emotional weight of any ending
The Skulz / Vinnie	Gizmo's coin; wasteland neglect	Gizmo; the dig; the town's fear	Dig-head; redeemable muscle	Fewer/ more deaths in the surge	<i>No row connects to nothing. The chain runs unbroken: the war built the reactor, the reactor lost its core to the past, the past made it a relic, the relic came home and pulled the knights with it, the town lives on the reactor's water, the feud's dig is killing it, and the knights alone hold the piece that decides whether the door opens or the town burns.</i>				

THE ONE-PAGE RUN SHEET

Premise. Crusading knights are flung 700 years forward by a dying pre-War time-reactor and land in Junktown, a scrap town on the brink of a gang war. They believe they're in Hell; they're actually standing on a machine that

summoned them to reclaim the "holy relic" they carry — which is its missing core. They have one night to learn the truth and choose what the relic is for.

Hidden truth. Site LAZARUS, a buried temporal reactor, threw its core into the past centuries ago, where it became the Order's Argent Heart; the failing reactor pulled the knights forward to get it back. Its coolant is Junktown's secret water; Gizmo's treasure-dig is accelerating its collapse. The next surge opens a door home if the Heart is seated — or tears the town apart if it isn't.

The cast. Killian (honest sheriff, guards the sealed door). Gizmo (dying crime boss, wants Killian dead and the "treasure"). Vane (ghoul Warden below, knows all, wants to give back the Heart and die). Corwin (mad knight from an earlier surge, speaks the truth as prophecy). Doc Morbid (grim healer, only radiation cure). Vinnie (Skulz leader, redeemable). Neal (bartender, gossip). Trisha (child at the well, human stakes).

The powers. Killian's Law · Gizmo's House · the Skulz · Site LAZARUS (Vane + the reactor).

The places. Gate & Square (hook) · Darkwater's Store & sealed cellar (honest road down) · the Skum Pitt & its dig (crooked road down) · Doc Morbid's · the Crash House (Corwin) · the Well & rusted hatch (hard road down) · the Skulz' Hole & dig-head · Site LAZARUS (finale).

The clock (7 surges). Warming → copper well → blue light → dig bites deep → first venting (radiation) → water fails → the tearing.

The clues that matter. The relic warms near the well/cellar; the glass scorch-ring; pre-War steel and rad-hatches; copper taste before quakes; the picks under the Pitt; Corwin's prophecy; Vane tells all.

Finale choices. Seat the Heart (save town, stranded forever) · take the Heart (go home, town burns) · destroy the reactor (clean end, no home, waterless town) · take Vane's place (living sacrifice) · fail (the tearing).

When in doubt. Stuck? Corwin, Neal, or Vane hands the truth. Stalled? Advance a surge — the relic burns hotter, the ground sings. Lost? The relic points the way. Fight looming? Guns are terrifying; talk, or turn the Skulz. Always end a scene on a choice, and always ask a knight what their oath demands.